E Lent 5 Grammar notes

Relative pronouns *"who…which…that…"*

- We already know that a PRONOUN is a word that stands in for another noun, to save it being constantly repeated. A RELATIVE PRONOUN is such a word, and **it is used to relate/link/join together two different ideas** in a neat and efficient way:

  - *Je connais une fille. Cette fille est jolie.*
  - *Je connais la fille QUI est jolie.*
  - *Elle a mangé une pizza. Je lui ai donné cette pizza.*
  - *Elle a mangé la pizza QUE je lui ai donnée.*

- The main words in French that function as RELATIVE PRONOUNS are **QUE, QUI** and **DONT**. It is **not** possible to say that "qui" = "who" and "que" = "that" etc. **You need to avoid falling into this trap**.

  - **QUI** is used when the "relative" is the SUBJECT of the verb, i.e. is doing the action

  La fille qui aime la musique, qui est là, qui s'est fait mal…

  - **QUE** is used when the "relative" is the DIRECT OBJECT of the verb, i.e. is having the action done to it.

  La fille que j'aime, que j'ai vue, que je voudrais inviter

  - **DONT** is used in the same way as QUE, but has a built in "**de**" that may be needed and cannot just be left at the end of the phrase

  La fille dont je parle (~~que je parle de~~), dont il rêve (~~qu'il rêve de~~)

- A simple way of checking is to make sure that QUI is used when a verb immediately follows and QUE/DONT is used when there is a word like "*je*" or a noun that follows.

- The three relative pronouns above link the information that follows them to the **SINGLE THING OR PERSON** that precedes the pronoun (i.e. la fille in all the above examples). Sometimes it is necessary to link the information that follows the relative pronoun to a **WHOLE IDEA, FACT or CLAUSE**. To achieve this, the same relative pronouns are used, but the word **CE** is used immediately in front of it.

  - *J'ai une radio dans ma chambre que j'aime* **(I like my ROOM)**
  - *J'ai une radio dans ma chambre, CE que j'aime* **(I like having a radio in my room)**
  - *Tu as déjà lu le livre qui est ennuyeux* **(the BOOK is boring)**
  - *Tu as déjà lu le livre, CE qui est ennuyeux* **(it's a pain that you've already read…)**

REVISION: y / en

- You will recall that **"y" is an indirect object pronoun** and therefore:
    - is placed before a conjugated verb or dependent infinitive
    - does not cause any PDO agreement as it is INDIRECT
    - comes in penultimate position in the table of the order of pronouns
- It frequently means "there" and is also used to refer to THINGS only for verbs that involve the **preposition à** (see F Sum 7):
    - Je vais à Paris et je vais y rester deux mois
    - J'adore Paris et j'y pense tout le temps
- It is of course found in the idiom **"il y a".** This impersonal idiom **can of course be used in any tense** and these common and useful examples should be learned as they are a frequent source of difficulty. They all refer to the existence of something, "there is" and the verb **ÊTRE is never used**.

il y a	PRESENT	*there is/are*
il y avait	IMPERFECT **(a non-event)**	*there was/were (a lot of people)*
il y a eu	PERFECT **(an event)**	*there was/were (an accident)*
il y aura	FUTURE	*there will be*
il y aurait	CONDITIONAL	*there would be*
il doit y avoir	present + DEVOIR	*there must be*
il devrait y avoir	conditional + DEVOIR	*there ought to be*
il a dû y avoir	perfect + DEVOIR	*there must have been (a delay)*
il devait y avoir	imperfect + DEVOIR	*there must have been (lots to drink)*
il pourrait y avoir	conditional + POUVOIR	*there might be*

- **"EN" is an indirect object pronoun** also, and goes in the same place as "y" and causes no agreements.
- It frequently means **"of them"** and is also used to refer to THINGS only for verbs that involve the **preposition "de"** (see F Sum 7)
- It should be remembered that **any expression of quantity that does not specify what is being "counted"** needs to use "en" – *"combien EN veux-tu?"*